

Claire Augusta Bergey

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Academic appointments

Assistant Professor of Cognitive Science, Vassar College, 2026–present

Postdoctoral scholar in Linguistics, Stanford University, 2024–2026

Postdoctoral scholar in Psychology, University of Wisconsin–Madison, 2023–2024

Education

PhD in Psychology, University of Chicago, 2023

MA in Psychology, University of Chicago, 2019

BA in Psychology conc. Cognitive Science, Williams College, 2017

Awards and fellowships

National Science Foundation SBE Postdoctoral Fellow (NSF SPRF), 2024–2026

Cognitive Science Society Disciplinary Diversity and Integration Award, 2025

University of Chicago Norman H. Anderson Award, 2021, 2023

Diverse Intelligences Summer Institute Fellow, 2021, 2023

John Dewey Prize Lectureship, 2022 (declined due to funding constraints)

Cognitive Science Society Prize for Computational Modeling in Language, 2021

Phi Beta Kappa, 2017

Sigma Xi Scientific Honors, 2017

Williams College Psychology Department 1960s Scholar, 2015–2017

Florence Chapman–Grace C. Dickinson Scholarship, 2016

Williams Bicentennial Psychology Scholarship, 2015

Publications

* Denotes equal contribution; + Denotes undergraduate mentee.

Bergey, C.A., * Morris, B. * & Yurovsky, D. (in revision). Language selectively encodes atypical features of the world. [[preprint](#)]

Bergey, C.A. & DeDeo, S. (in revision). From "um" to "yeah": Producing, predicting, and regulating information flow in human conversation. [[preprint](#)]

Ji, A., Bergey, C.A., Eliav, R., Artzi, Y., & Hawkins, R.D. (under review). Ad hoc conventions generalize to new referents. [[preprint](#)]

- Schmidt, H., Bergey, C.A., Zhou, C.,⁺ Helion, C., & Hawkins, R.D. (2025). Dynamics of topic exploration in conversation. *Proceedings of the 47th Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society*. [[link](#)]
- Tsvilodub, P., Hawkins, R.D., Bergey, C.A., Goodman, N.D., Franke, M. (2025). Relevant answers to polar questions. *Philosophical Transactions of the Royal Society B*, 380(1932), 20230505. [[link](#)]
- Bergey, C.A., O’Keeffe, M.E.,⁺ Hawkins, R.D. (2024). A longitudinal analysis of children’s communicative acts. *Proceedings of the 46th Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society*. [[link](#)]
- Bergey, C.A. & Yurovsky, D. (2023). Using contrastive inferences to learn about new words and categories. *Cognition*, 241, 105597. [[link](#)]
- Zettersten, M., Yurovsky, D., Xu, T.L., Uner, S., Tsui, A., Schneider, R.M., Saleh, A., Meylan, S., Marchman, V.A., Mankewitz, J., MacDonald, K., Long, B., Lewis, M., Kachergis, G., Handa, K., deMayo, B., Carstensen, A., Braginsky, M., Boyce, V., Bhatt, N., Bergey, C.A., Frank, M.C. (2022). Peekbank: An open, large-scale repository for developmental eye-tracking data of children’s word recognition. *Behavior Research Methods*, 55(5), 2485-2500. [[link](#)]
- Bergey, C., Marshall, Z.,⁺ DeDeo, S. & Yurovsky, D. (2022). Learning communicative acts in children’s conversations: a Hidden Topic Markov Model analysis of the CHILDES corpora. *Topics in Cognitive Science*, 14(2), 388-399. [[link](#)]
- Zettersten, M., Bergey, C., Bhatt, N., Boyce, V., Braginsky, M., Carstensen, A., deMayo, B., Kachergis, G., Lewis, M., Long, B., MacDonald, K., Mankewitz, J., Meylan, S., Saleh, A., M. Schneider, R., Tsui, A., Uner, S., Xu, T.L., Yurovsky, D., Frank, M.C. (2021). Peekbank: Exploring children’s word recognition through an open, large-scale repository for developmental eye-tracking data. *Proceedings of the 43rd annual meeting of the Cognitive Science Society*. [[link](#)]
- Bergey, C. & Yurovsky, D. (2020). Listeners use descriptive contrast to disambiguate novel referents and make inferences about novel categories. *Proceedings of Experiments in Linguistic Meaning*. [[link](#)]
- Bergey, C.* , Morris, B.* & Yurovsky, D. (2020). Children hear more about what is atypical than what is typical. *Proceedings of the 42nd Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society*. [[link](#)]

Talks

- Mankewitz, J., Altenhof, A.M., Bergey, C.A., & Hawkins, R.D. (to be presented 2025). Not-A Corpus: Characterizing parents’ use of contrast in negated utterances.

- Boston University Conference on Language Development.
- Bergey, C.A., O'Keeffe, M.E.,⁺ & Hawkins, R.D. (2025). How children do things with words. Global Developmental Psychology Workshop.
- Bergey, C.A., Casillas, M., Messinger, D., & Sparks, R.Z. (2025). Children's choice of conversational partners. Symposium organizer: Naturalistic observation of language development outside the home. 47th Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society.
- Martin, J.,⁺ Casillas, M., King, S., & Bergey, C.A. (2023). Copula absence variation in adult and child corpus speech. Boston University Conference on Language Development 48.
- Zettersten, M., Bergey, C.A., and the Peekbank team (2022). Peekbank: Exploring children's word recognition through an open, large-scale repository for developmental eye-tracking data. Plenary Symposium: Methodological advances in gaze-based measures of language understanding. Boston University Conference on Language Development 47.
- Bergey, C., Marshall, Z.,⁺ DeDeo, S. & Yurovsky, D. (2021). Learning communicative acts in children's conversations: a Hidden Topic Markov Model analysis of the CHILDES corpus. 43rd annual meeting of the Cognitive Science Society.
- Bergey, C., Morris, B., & Yurovsky, D. (2021). Remarking on the atypical: Implications for language learning and modeling. Dubrovnik Conference on Cognitive Science.
- Bergey, C.* , Morris, B.* & Yurovsky, D. (2021). Children hear more about what is atypical than what is typical. Symposium: The Role of Language in Concept Acquisition in Typical and Atypical Populations. Meeting of the Society for Research in Child Development.
- Bergey, C. & Yurovsky, D. (2020). Listeners use descriptive contrast to disambiguate novel referents and make inferences about novel categories. Experiments in Linguistic Meaning.
- Bergey, C.* , Morris, B.* & Yurovsky, D. (2020). Children hear more about what is atypical than what is typical. 42nd annual meeting of the Cognitive Science Society.
- Bergey, C. & Yurovsky, D. (2020). Children use presupposition to infer new word-referent mappings. Budapest CEU Conference on Cognitive Development.
- Bergey, C. & Yurovsky, D. (2018). When over-description is informative: Specification prompts inferences about a referent's category. Midwestern Cognitive Science Conference.

Poster presentations

- Bergey, C., O’Keeffe, M.E.,+ Lyu, A.,+ Yang, S.,+ Zubak, Y., Plum, B.,+ Patil, A.,+ Li, B.,+ Zhou, C.,+ Nguyen, H.,+ Markley, M.,+ & Hawkins, R.D. (2025). Social interaction from a preschooler’s point of view. The Long-form Recording Interdisciplinary Summit.
- Zettersten, M., Bergey, C., Bhatt, N., Boyce, V., Braginsky, M., Carstensen, A., deMayo, B., Kachergis, G., Lewis, M., Long, B., MacDonald, K., Mankewitz, J., Meylan, S., Saleh, A., M. Schneider, R., Tsui, A., Uner, S., Xu, T.L., Yurovsky, D., Frank, M.C. (2021). Peekbank: Exploring children’s word recognition through an open, large-scale repository for developmental eye-tracking data. 43rd annual meeting of the Cognitive Science Society.
- Bergey, C., Kisa, Y., Casasanto, D., & Yurovsky, D. (2020). Where does the conceptual space–time asymmetry come from? 42nd annual meeting of the Cognitive Science Society.
- Zaki, S. & Bergey, C. (2019). Juxtaposition during training induces category-specific effects on accuracy and feature attention. 60th annual meeting of the Psychonomic Society.
- Bergey, C. & Yurovsky, D. (2019). Children use presupposition to infer new word-referent mappings. Biennial meeting of the Cognitive Development Society.
- Morris, B., Bergey, C. & Yurovsky, D. (2019). Child language input does not reflect world frequency: Typical and atypical feature description across development. 41st annual meeting of the Cognitive Science Society.
- Bergey, C. & Yurovsky, D. (2019). Listeners use descriptive contrast to disambiguate novel referents. 41st annual meeting of the Cognitive Science Society.
- Bergey, C. & Yurovsky, D. (2018). Available referents and prompt specificity influence induction of feature typicality. 40th annual meeting of the Cognitive Science Society.

Teaching

University of Chicago

- Introduction to Language Acquisition (2022), section leader and guest lecturer
- Seminar in Language Acquisition (2022), teaching assistant
- Psychology of Communication (2021, 2022), teaching assistant and guest lecturer
- Introduction to Developmental Psychology (2021), section leader
- Introduction to Learning and Memory (2021), section leader

Cognitive Psychology (2020), section leader
Fundamentals of Psychology (2020), section leader
Williams College
Introduction to Cognitive Psychology (2014), teaching assistant

Mentorship

Stanford University: Charlotte Burnham, Oliver Lee, Abel Gebretinsae, Hoang Nguyen, Van Le Tran, Edvard Sohlberg, Mary Markley.

University of Wisconsin-Madison: Misha O’Keeffe, Ashrita Patil, Changyi Zhou, Artem Lyu, Senyi Yang, Biying Li, Benjamin Plum.

Carnegie Mellon University: Zoe Marshall.

University of Chicago: Jordyn Martin, Jayda Hart.

Service

Peekbank database team (2020–present)

UChicago Reproduciblitea Organizer (2021–2022)

Undergraduate Research Mentor, University of Chicago (2021–2023)

Williams Psychology Department Student Liaison Committee (2016–2017)

Reviews: *Cognition*, *Journal of Memory and Language*, *Cognitive Science*, *Child Development*, *Open Mind*, *Glossa Psycholinguistics*, *Behavior Research Methods*, *Language Learning and Development*, *repliCATS*, *Proceedings of the Cognitive Science Society*, *Budapest CEU Conference on Cognitive Development*, *Architectures and Mechanisms for Language Processing*.

Other work

Set designer (2026), *FIRE HOUSE*, Chicago Shpatz

Founding member and Arts Working Group (2025–), Mouse Arts & Letters Club

Research assistant (2015–2017), Concepts and Categories Lab at Williams College

Graphic designer (2016–2017), Williams College Center for Learning in Action

Scene shop construction & electrics (2013–2017), Williams College Theatre Department

Technical Director (2013–2017), Cap & Bells theatre organization